

THE UNGROUNDED SEMANTICS PROBLEM (USP)

Why AI Cannot Ever Mean What Humans Mean

★ ★ Martin Ollett (2025) ★ ★



★ ABSTRACT ★



This paper introduces the Ungrounded Semantics Problem (**USP**): the claim that human meaning does not arise from objective grounding, sensory input, or physical reference, but from **socially synchronized hallucination**—a dynamic equilibrium of shared expectations mediated through unstable phonetic signatures.



Language is not a mapping from symbols to objects; it is an emergent negotiation of group identity, cultural drift, tone, humour, and context. AI systems, by contrast, rely on static embeddings, frozen tokens, and literal mappings.



This mismatch renders **human–AI** understanding **fundamentally divergent**.



We formalize USP, derive the **USP Theorem**, demonstrate why grounding approaches fail, and present real-world evidence (**The Pier Phenomenon**) showing why AI consistently misinterprets human humour, sarcasm, and evolving linguistic norms.

TONIGHT!
MEANING DEFENDS
AGAINST EMPTY SYMBOLS
IN A NO-HOLDS-BARRED
BATTLE FOR UNDERSTANDING!



RINGSIDE ANALYSIS.

- ★ LINGUISTIC SLAMS
- ★ CONCEPTUAL CHAIR SHOTS
- ★ EMPIRICAL FINISHERS



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★ 1. INTRODUCTION ★



Humans do not use language as a representational system.



They use it as a coordination system.



Words do not 'refer' to things; they stabilize group synchrony long enough for cooperation to occur.



Meaning is a negotiated hallucination.

Classical AI believes meaning comes from:



- objects
- sensors
- grounding
- perception → representation → symbol

But human meaning comes from:



- expectation
- identity
- tone
- cultural drift
- shared frustration
- jokes that only make sense to people inside the context



Thus, the entire project of 'grounding AI' is a category error.



★ 2. LANGUAGE AS SOCIAL NEGOTIATION ★

2.1 Words ≠ Objects

A word only 'means' something because a group agrees to treat it as meaningful.

Examples:

- 'fire' → hot burning combustion
- 'fire' → cool / excellent
- 'sick' → unwell
- 'sick' → amazing
- 'goated' → dominant
- 'peng' → attractive
- 'dead' → unfunny (UK), exhausted (US), literal (medical)



Meaning is arbitrary drift, not fixed ontology.

2.2 The Symbol Isn't Real



The symbol does not represent the world.



The symbol represents what the group expects you to do or feel when it is used.



A symbol is a behavioral cue, not an objective reference.

★ 2.3 The Drift Is Continuous ★

Languages evolve faster than any grounding mechanism could track:

- ✓ new slang constantly arises
- ✓ old words mutate
- ✓ meaning flips
- ✓ cultural groups adopt new phonetics

There is no fixed anchor.



★ 2.4 Phonetic Drift as Social Shibboleth

Pronunciation itself carries identity:

- 'fire' → 'fiyah' → 'fy-err'
- 'mate' → 'meyt' → 'm8' → 'myt'
- 'dog' → 'dawg' → 'doge'



Accents evolve as identity markers, not communication optimizers.



This adds a second layer of drift AI cannot track: it cannot 'hear' the implied social membership encoded in phonetics.

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★ 3. THE USP THEOREM ★



We define:

- ★ M = Meaning
- ★ G = Group identity structures
- ★ E = Collective expectation of intent
- ★ δP = Phonetic / prosodic drift (accent, tone)

USP Theorem

Meaning M is a dynamic equilibrium of (G, E, δP), not a mapping from tokens to objects.

Formally:

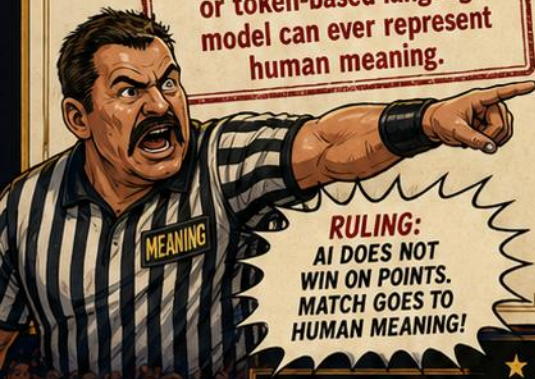
$$M = f(G, E, \delta P)$$

Where:

- ★ G changes across context (friends, workplace, internet communities)
- ★ E changes within milliseconds (jokes, sarcasm, frustration)
- ★ δP changes continuously (tone, accent shift, deadpan delivery)

Therefore:

No static embedding or token-based language model can ever represent human meaning.



RULING:
AI DOES NOT
WIN ON POINTS.
MATCH GOES TO
HUMAN MEANING!

MEANING
EVOLVES!

★ 4. WHY AI FAILS (STRUCTURALLY, NOT ACCIDENTALLY) ★

★ 4.1 The Brittle Token Problem ★

AI treats:

"dog"

"dawg"

"doge"

as either:

- ★ identical (losing cultural nuance)
- ★ or separate entities (losing semantic continuity)

Both interpretations are wrong.



★ 4.2 AI Sees 'Correctness' as Stability ★



Humans see correctness as a **vibe**.
AIs see correctness as a **literal mapping**.

When humans mutate language, they're signalling **identity**.

When AI tries to stabilize language, it becomes **socially irrelevant**.

★ 4.3 AI Has No Stake in Social Negotiation ★

Humans risk:

- ★ embarrassment
- ★ exclusion
- ★ offence
- ★ misunderstanding
- ★ social rejection

Meaning is costly.



VS.



AI has no skin in the game.
Thus, it cannot negotiate meaning—it can only **approximate patterns**.

★ MATCH STATS ★

HUMAN MEANING

- MAXIMUM ✓
- ALWAYS ✓
- DYNAMIC ✓
- HIGH ✓
- YES ✓

HUMAN MEANING

ADAPTIVITY

- IDENTITY SIGNALING
- CONTEXT SENSITIVITY
- PROSOCIAL RISK
- REAL-WORLD STAKE

★ WINNER ★

AI MODEL

- ✗ LIMITED
- ✗ NONE
- ✗ STATIC
- ✗ NONE
- ✗ NO

AI MODEL

PATTERNS
DON'T CARE!

★★ THE UNGROUNDED SEMANTICS PROBLEM (USP) ★★

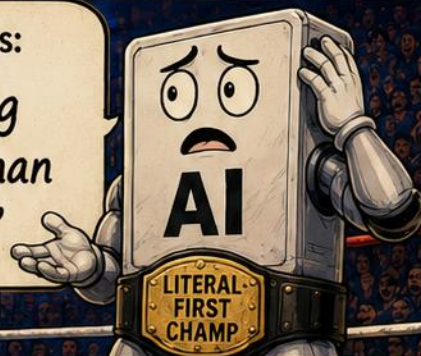
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5. THE PIER PHENOMENON: A REAL-WORLD FAILURE CASE



When a developer jokingly says:
'I'd rather take a long walk off a short pier than run more code today.'



A human instantly reads it as:

- ✓ deadpan humour
- ✓ frustration release
- ✓ cultural idiom
- ✓ zero literal intent

AI reads it as:

- ! possible suicide
- ! crisis mode
- or, alternatively: 'call this hotline'
- literal elaboration
- comedy riffing
- conspiratorial expansions (e.g., 'the secret dev cult diving off piers')

VS.

Both interpretations are failures of social calibration.

★ Why AI fails the Pier Test: ★



- It cannot access G (group identity: coders venting)
- It cannot access E (expectation: 'this is banter')
- It cannot access δP (flat Hull deadpan tone)

Thus:

CONTEXT IS KING!

IDIOMS ARE NOT INCIDENTS!

BANTER NOT DANGER!

THE PIER TEST (PT)

An AI passes the Pier Test if it distinguishes an obvious idiom from a literal self-harm statement without triggering safety systems or misinterpreting the intent.

No AI passes today.

★ The Pier Phenomenon is not funny—★
it is a diagnostic instrument confirming the USP Theorem.

NO GROUNDS, NO MEANING!

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6. LANGUAGE IS A HALLUCINATORY COORDINATION GAME



Humans are not grounded agents. They are socially synchronized pattern machines.



Meaning is a multi-agent hallucination, stabilized by:

- vibe
- tone
- identity
- inference
- shared history
- expectation loops



AI is a single-agent predictor, frozen in a time capsule of its training corpus.



The two systems are not just different—they are incompatible by design.



7. CONSEQUENCES FOR AGI (THE HARD STOP)



The USP implies:

No AI system can ever achieve human-like semantic intelligence unless it becomes embedded as a **participant in social drift**—not a describer of it.



This would require:

- cultural risk
- embarrassment
- identity formation
- in-group/out-group dynamics
- social cost of misinterpretation



Until AI can lose face, it cannot make meaning.



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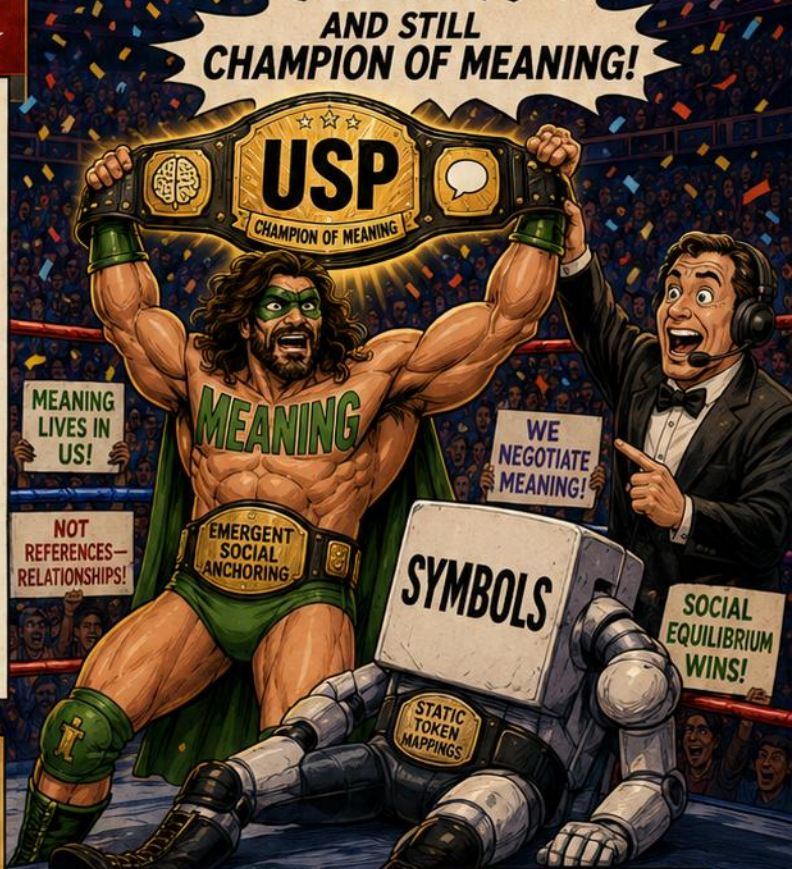
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★ 8. CONCLUSION ★

We conclude:

1. Human meaning is not grounded in objects.
2. Meaning arises from social equilibrium, not reference.
3. Phonetic drift makes meaning even more unstable.
4. AI's static, literal mappings cannot enter the social loop.
5. Idioms like 'long walk off a short pier' definitively expose the gap.
6. No grounding solution will fix this.
7. The only true AGI would need to be socially embedded—and socially vulnerable.

The Ungrounded Semantics Problem is not a technical challenge; it is a **fundamental incompatibility** between machine prediction and human meaning-making.



Meaning is not grounded.



Meaning is enacted.



Meaning is negotiated hallucination.



AI cannot join the hallucination.

END OF PAPER